

CEAC BESS Working Group
Key Economic and Community Considerations for Local Engagement
June 18, 2026

Battery energy storage systems, or BESS, help save electricity for when it is needed most. For local officials and community members, the key questions are how these projects may affect energy costs, grid reliability, safety, and local review.

A. Economic Considerations Most Relevant to Battery Storage

1st Consideration: BESS can help reduce pressure on electric bills.

- Electric bills are affected by both the cost of buying electricity and the cost of delivering it through wires, substations, transformers, and other grid infrastructure.
- BESS can reduce costs by storing electricity when demand is lower and using it when demand is highest, such as hot summer afternoons and evenings when air conditioning use is high.
- This matters because the electric system must be built to handle the highest-demand hours of the year, even if those peaks only happen for short periods.
- By reducing strain during those peak hours, BESS can help avoid or delay expensive upgrades to wires, substations, transformers, and other infrastructure that are ultimately paid for by customers.

2nd Consideration: BESS reduces reliance on the most expensive power.

- Electricity is often more expensive during high-demand periods because the grid must rely on more costly sources of power to meet peak needs.
- BESS can charge when electricity is more available and discharge when electricity is more expensive or harder to supply.
- This can help lower the cost of serving peak demand and reduce the need to rely on older, more expensive fossil-fuel power plants that are only used during high-demand periods.

3rd Consideration: BESS helps protect communities from fuel price volatility.

- In parts of New York, the electric system still relies heavily on fossil fuels, especially natural gas. When natural gas prices rise, electric supply costs can rise too, and those costs are often passed through to customers.
- BESS does not eliminate this problem on its own, but it can reduce dependence on fossil-fuel generation during peak periods by making stored electricity available when demand is high.

4th Consideration: BESS supports local grid reliability.

- BESS can provide power during high-demand periods, reduce local grid stress, and support local solar and other renewable energy.

- In areas where the grid is constrained, BESS can reduce the risk of overloads and outages by shifting some electricity use away from the busiest hours.
- This can be especially important as homes, businesses, vehicles, heating systems, cooling systems, and new technologies use more electricity.

5th Consideration: BESS helps support local economic benefits.

- BESS projects can provide local tax revenue, lease payments to participating property owners, construction and maintenance work, and infrastructure that supports the local electric system.
- When paired with solar, storage can also help make better use of locally produced electricity by saving power for the times when it is most useful.
- For community solar subscribers, local solar projects may provide direct bill savings, while paired BESS can increase the value and usefulness of that local clean energy.

B. Non-Economic Considerations

6th Consideration: BESS is not the same as e-bike or scooter batteries.

- Large BESS projects should not be confused with smaller consumer batteries used in e-bikes, scooters, or mopeds.
- BESS projects in New York must go through safety testing, permitting, code review, inspections, and local emergency planning before they can operate.
- These projects are built with safety systems that can detect problems, shut equipment down, and alert operators before a problem becomes more serious.

7th Consideration: New York has strong safety rules.

- Battery storage projects in New York must follow state fire and building codes, national safety standards, and local review requirements.
- New York's updated rules require more review before projects are built, more coordination with local fire departments, emergency response plans, firefighter training, and access to trained experts if an incident occurs.
- Local governments also have an important role in reviewing where projects are placed, how they are designed, how emergency responders will access the site, and how nearby residents will be protected.

8th Consideration: Modern BESS projects are designed with layers of protection.

- Modern BESS designs include temperature controls, smoke and gas detectors, fire-resistant containers, automatic shutoff systems, remote monitoring, spacing between units, and emergency procedures developed with local responders.
- In plain terms, the system is designed to notice a problem early, shut down the affected equipment, and keep the problem from spreading.
- All risks can be reviewed, planned for, and reduced before a project is built.

9th Consideration: Responsible local review is better than blanket bans.

- Residents and local officials should ask practical questions about safety, site location, fire department access, noise, visual screening, stormwater, maintenance, and decommissioning.
- These issues can be addressed through the local review process, where municipalities can require project-specific information about equipment, safety testing, site layout, emergency plans, setbacks, fencing, landscaping, operating conditions, and end-of-life plans.
- BESS is energy infrastructure, and no form of energy infrastructure is completely risk-free. The goal should be to review and manage projects responsibly, rather than ignore community concerns or impose broad bans that may block well-designed projects with reliability, pollution-reduction, grid, and clean energy benefits.

C. Bottom Line

- BESS can help New York save electricity for when it is needed most, reduce strain on the grid, support local reliability, and help avoid or delay expensive infrastructure upgrades.
- It should not be described as risk-free, but in New York it is subject to strong safety rules, multiple layers of protection, local review, and emergency planning.
- For local officials and community members, the key question is how to review, site, and monitor these projects responsibly so that communities can receive the benefits while safety remains the top priority.